

SpaceX and the Falcon 9

SpaceX (Space Exploration Technologies Corp.) was founded on 14 March 2002 by Elon Musk, who had just sold PayPal to eBay for USD 1.5 billion. The company's first office was in El Segundo, California, before moving to Hawthorne in 2008.

The Falcon 1 was SpaceX's first orbital launch vehicle. After three failed launches in 2006, 2007, and 2008, Falcon 1 successfully placed the RazakSAT satellite in orbit on 14 September 2008, becoming the first privately developed liquid-fueled rocket to reach orbit.

The Falcon 9, named for its nine Merlin engines, first launched on 4 June 2010 from Cape Canaveral. The Falcon 9 v1.1 first flew in September 2013, and the current "Full Thrust" version in December 2015. On 21 December 2015, Falcon 9 performed the first successful vertical landing of an orbital-class rocket stage, at Landing Zone 1 at Cape Canaveral.

The Dragon spacecraft became the first commercial spacecraft to dock with the International Space Station on 25 May 2012. The Crew Dragon carried NASA astronauts Bob Behnken and Doug Hurley to the ISS on 30 May 2020 in the Demo-2 mission, the first crewed orbital launch from US soil since the Space Shuttle's retirement in 2011.

The Starship program, conducted at the SpaceX Starbase facility near Boca Chica, Texas, achieved its first successful orbital flight and splashdown on 14 March 2024. The Super Heavy booster was caught by the launch tower's "chopstick" arms on 13 October 2024.